

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Play Beats Flashcards: What the Research Says

And 20 everyday learning moments · Ages 2–4

Young children learn by doing, touching, talking and exploring. Drilling facts can look impressive, but real understanding grows through play and everyday life.

What the research found

- ○ Infants who watched a popular vocabulary DVD for a month learned no more words than those who didn't; the most learning happened when parents taught words in everyday interaction (DeLoache et al., 2010).
- ○ Developmental scientists argue play and conversation build the foundations of learning better than early drilling (Hirsh-Pasek, Golinkoff & Eyer, 2003).

Everyday learning moments

- ○ Count spoons while setting the table
- ○ Name colours at the sabzi market
- ○ Compare big and small potatoes
- ○ Sort laundry by colour
- ○ Talk about the weather on the balcony
- ○ Spot shapes on a walk: round wheels, square windows
- ○ Measure and pour while cooking
- ○ Sing rhymes in your home language
- ○ Read and talk about the pictures
- ○ Pretend play: shop, doctor, kitchen

Good 'learning toys'

- ○ Blocks
- ○ Simple puzzles
- ○ Play dough
- ○ Kitchen tools
- ○ Books
- ○ Open-ended objects: boxes, cloths, pegs

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

DeLoache, J. S., et al. (2010). Do babies learn from baby media? Psychological Science, 21(11), 1570–1574.
Hirsh-Pasek, K., Golinkoff, R. M., & Eyer, D. (2003). Einstein Never Used Flash Cards. Rodale.

Free to print and share.